run out. The match was tied but Australia went through to the final because they had finished higher on the Super Six table. I remember my father being so angry. He could not believe how we had lost. I just ran to my bedroom and cried.

We were all watching on television again in 2003, when South Africa were hosts and we had to beat Sri Lanka in Durban, and we were on course to win with rain coming. There was confusion over the reduced target, and we thought we were on track when the downpour arrived, but we weren't. We were level, which meant the match was tied, again, and so we were eliminated from our own World Cup by the slimmest of margins.

In 2007, we collapsed to 27 for five in the semifinal against Australia in St Lucia and were well beaten by the eventual winners and, four years later in 2011, we seemed on track to win the quarterfinal against New Zealand in Dhaka but then floundered and fell well short of a modest target of 222.

Six Cricket World Cups had inspired so much hope, and delivered six national disappointments.

Still, I kept having the same dream …

It is the ICC Cricket World Cup final and I am fielding at cover. The batsman is left-handed and he drives, making a solid connection. I dive to my right, gather the ball at full stretch, jump to my feet, run towards the stumps and take off the bails. We appeal. The umpire's finger is raised, and South Africa wins the World Cup.

And still I kept waking up …

Maybe 2015 was going to be our year. The Cricket World Cup was being hosted by Australia and New Zealand, presenting us with what started to feel like the perfect opportunity to move beyond the history of frustration and pain. As the tournament approached, I started to feel more and more confident that our time had come. As captain, I sensed a real belief within the squad, a collective resolve to banish the 'chokers' tag forever.